

MICHAEL G. CUNA

michaelcuna@uchicago.edu – www.michaelgcuna.com – (941) 914-7708

Education

University of Chicago, Ph.D. Economics 2026

Barcelona School of Economics, M.Sc. Economics 2017

References

Professor Leonardo Bursztyn (Co-Chair)
University of Chicago
Kenneth C. Griffin Department of Economics
bursztyn@uchicago.edu

Professor John List (Co-Chair)
University of Chicago
Kenneth C. Griffin Department of Economics
jlist@uchicago.edu

Professor Alex Imas
University of Chicago
Booth School of Business
alex.imas@chicagobooth.edu

Research and Teaching Fields

Primary: Behavioral Economics, Management
Secondary: Applied Microeconomics, Experimental Economics

Job Market Paper

The Hidden Curriculum (with Elaine Shen)

Abstract: We study the hidden curriculum: informal, tacit strategies crucial for academic and career success. These unobserved skill gaps are a critical barrier to information acquisition and limit upward mobility. Using observational data from over 100,000 U.S. college students, we document significant gaps in academic and labor market outcomes, with first-generation students falling behind continuing-generation peers in “hidden” actions like proactively engaging with faculty and joining organizations. Through a field experiment at UC Berkeley, we identify two main channels driving this gap: lack of awareness and low subjective beliefs about returns. Information treatments substantially increase willingness to invest in hidden curriculum actions for first-generation students, closing the gap with their more informed peers. Finally, we develop an AI college advisor to further isolate these mechanisms in an online experiment. At baseline, first-generation students devote less search effort to hidden curriculum topics and exhibit lower propensity to switch topics. However, when the AI actively steers conversations toward hidden curriculum actions-increasing awareness-these gaps narrow, providing additional evidence that information constraints drive hidden curriculum underinvestment.

Working Papers

What Happens When the Taliban Leave? Evidence from a Field Experiment and Survey in Pakistan (with Musharraf Cyan, M. Taha Kasim, John A. List, and Michael K. Price)

Abstract: From newborns to the elderly, exposure to violence and conflict has been found to have deleterious effects. In this study, we explore a unique type of violence: exposure to the Taliban. Pairing a field experiment with a field survey among citizens in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP), Pakistan, we examine

how exposure to violence affects general trust, subjective well-being, and confidence in institutions. In our field experiment, we observe that exposure to conflict significantly alters the relative valuation of monetary rewards for oneself compared to those for a comparable peer. Specifically, individuals subjected to violence demonstrate a marked tendency to prioritize their own financial gain over that of a similar other. In the survey, we find that exposure to violence is associated with reduced general trust, trust in informal institutions, and subjective well-being. Interestingly, being exposed to violence increases trust in formal institutions. Our combined results highlight that the interplay between violence and trust dynamics is complex and highly consequential. In turn, the policy implications highlight the need for a multifaceted strategy to support individuals and communities affected by violence, ensuring both immediate relief and long-term resilience.

The Role of Risk and Ambiguity Preferences on Early-Childhood Investment: Evidence from Rural India (Lenka Fiala, Min Sok Lee, John A. List, and Sutanuka Roy)

Abstract: Understanding the role of preferences, beliefs, and constraints on social and wealth inequities is a key unlock for economic growth. This study focuses on the inter-relationship between risk and ambiguity preferences of mothers, their early childhood investments, and their children's outcomes. To do so, we jointly elicit ambiguity attitude and risk aversion preference parameters from more than 6000 randomly sampled mothers from nearly 500 villages in the district of Udaipur in Rajasthan, India. Across several measures of mothers' investment in nutrition of their children between the ages of 0-6, we find a robust and stable positive correlation of estimated ambiguity attitude and risk aversion parameters with maternal investments in children: the more risk and ambiguity averse the mother, the greater her maternal investments. Such investments are correlated with better children's cognitive and non-cognitive skills, as mothers with greater risk and ambiguity aversion have children with superior skills, even after accounting for socio-economic differences. Importantly, the positive effect of ambiguity and risk aversion on early-life outcomes can attenuate the negative impact of proxies of socio-economic disadvantage, such as illiteracy of the mothers, belonging to historically discriminated social groups, no exposure to radio, television, or zero access to mobile phones for all measures of cognitive and non-cognitive early-life skills.

Stated Preferences, Social Signaling, and Construct Validity: Evidence From a Field Experiment in Rural India (Lenka Fiala, Min Sok Lee, John A. List, and Sutanuka Roy)

Abstract: We study stated vs revealed preferences in an early childhood vaccination information intervention. In Rajasthan, India, we run a randomized field experiment with mothers of vaccine-eligible children. At baseline, we collect a set of rich covariates and then implement an information intervention guided by the standard international health organizations protocols that addresses common concerns, and highlights benefits. We then return to the same villages and collect long-term vaccination outcomes. We find that the information intervention significantly increased positive survey responses on stated willingness to take up the remaining vaccinations for their children, but had negligible effects on actual vaccination rates. Motivated by this gap we develop a model to make precise predictions for two mechanisms –social signalling and construct validity– and propose tips for optimal experimental design –not eliminating social desirability bias in experiments, but matching it to the desired field behavior.

Work in Progress

AI, Beliefs, and Job Search (with Marion Carr and Elaine Shen)

Abstract: We study human AI interaction in job expectations and job search behavior by partnering with an AI-powered job-tech startup. The increasing availability and sophistication of AI tools in the labor market—from resume builders to personalized cover letter generators—has reshaped how job seekers navigate the job search process. A prevailing assumption is that AI tools should increase the speed of job applications and provide users with informative signals about what types of jobs to apply for and how to apply. Users would then use the information generated by AI to update their job application

material and beliefs in a Bayesian fashion. However, users may have reasons to override recommendations, either because they correctly or incorrectly believe themselves to be more knowledgeable than the AI tools, or because they have ego concerns or motivated reasoning to reinforce their existing beliefs. We first document human-AI interaction in the job search process using a proprietary dataset on job searches, job application material (CVs, cover letters, etc.) and job outcomes. We find that AI job search tools are associated with an increase in the number of jobs applied to, but don't necessarily lead to more job offers and job matches. To understand the mechanisms behind this pattern, we are in the process of fielding an experiment that will randomize the type and presentation of AI-generated advice to examine how recommendations affect user expectations, application quality, and longer-term employment outcomes.

Hidden Curriculum and Job Market Signals

Contingent Valuation and Social Utility (with Franco D. Albino, Alec Brandon and John A. List)

Scale, Representativeness, and Trust in Science (with Omar Al-Ubaydli and John A. List)

Social Signaling and Altruistic Motives for Sustainable Investments

Awards, Scholarships, and Grants

Benjamin Bloom Dissertation Fellowship	2025-2026
CV Starr Fellowship	2025-2026
Harry G. Johnson Fellowship	2025-2026
University of Chicago Behavioral Economics Research Fund (\$9,800)	2025
University of Chicago Data Acquisition Grant (\$3,000)	2025
Becker Friedman Institute Political Economics Initiative Grant (\$5,000)	2023
University of Chicago Social Sciences Division Fellowship	2019-

Teaching Experience

A Course in Experimental Economics (PhD)	TA for Prof. List	Winter 2024
Experimental Economics (Undergraduate)	Co-Lecturer with Prof. List	Winter 2023
Introduction to Behavioral and Experimental Economics (Undergraduate)	TA for Prof. Lee	Fall 2022
Economics from an Experimental Perspective (High School at U Chicago)	TA for Prof. Lee	Summer 2022
Topics in Behavioral Economics (PhD)	TA for Prof. Bursztyn	Winter 2022
Practicalities in RCTs (Master's and PhD)	TA for Prof. Glennerster	Fall 2021
Economics from an Experimental Perspective (High School)	TA for Prof. Lee	Summer 2021
A Course in Experimental Economics (PhD)	TA for Prof. List	Spring 2021

Research Experience and Other Employment

Associate Director, Chicago Experiments	2021–2024
Research Professional for Professor John List, BFI	2017–2019
Junior Asset Manager, Banca Ifigest	2015-2016
Kairos Partners, New York	2014-2015

Professional Experience

Conferences	<i>Economic Science Association, World Meeting (2026), Advancements in Field Experiments, University of Chicago (2025), Ninth Biennial Meeting of the Social Dilemmas Working Group, Indiana University at Bloomington (2025), Conference on Field Experiments in Accounting and Finance, Georgetown (2024), Advancements in Field Experiments, University of Chicago (2023)</i>
Presentations	<i>London School of Economics Department of Management (2026), Microsoft Research (2026), Applied Micro Brown Bag, University of Notre Dame (2025), Mitch Daniels School of Business, Purdue University (2025), Tippie College of Business, University of Iowa (2025), University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (2025), Marquette University, College of Business Administration (2025), Washington University in St. Louis, Olin Business School (2025), DePaul Applied Micro Seminar (2024), Experimental Economics Seminar, University of Chicago (2023)</i>
Refereeing Activity	<i>Journal of Political Economy, Journal of Political Economy: Microeconomics , Journal of Applied Economics, Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization</i>

Additional Information

Citizenship	USA, Italy
Languages	English, Italian